Let’s start by making things even a little more extreme. Imagine that the length of the circular dimension of the Garden-hose universe is very short—so short that neither you nor any of your fellow Hose-dwellers are even aware of its existence. Instead, you and everyone else living in the Hose universe take one basic fact of life to be so evident as to be beyond questioning: the universe has one spatial dimension. (If the Garden-hose universe had produced its own ant-Einstein, Hose-dwellers would say that the universe has one spatial and one time dimension.) In fact, this feature is so self-evident that Hose-dwellers have named their home Lineland, directly emphasizing its having one spatial dimension.

Life in Lineland is very different from life as we know it. For example, the body with which you are familiar cannot fit in Lineland. No matter how much effort you may put into body reshaping, one thing you can’t get around is that you definitely have length, width, and breadth—spatial extent in three dimensions. In Lineland there is no room for such an extravagant design. Remember, although your mental image of Lineland may still be tied to a long, threadlike object existing in our space, you really need to think of Lineland as a universe—all there is. As an inhabitant of Lineland you must fit within its spatial extent. Try to imagine it. Even if you take on an ant’s body, you still will not fit. You must squeeze your ant body to look more like a worm, and then further squeeze it until you have no thickness at all. To fit in Lineland you must be a being that has only length.

Imagine further that you have an eye on each end of your body. Unlike your human eyes, which can swivel around to look in all three dimensions, your eyes as a Linebeing are forever locked into position, each staring off into the one-dimensional distance. This is not an anatomical limitation of your new body. Instead, you and all other Linebeings recognize that since Lineland has but one dimension, there simply isn’t another direction in which your eyes can look. Forward and backward exhaust the extent of Lineland.

We can try to go further in imagining life in Lineland, but we quickly realize that there’s not much more to it. For instance, if another Linebeing is on one or the other side of you, picture how it will appear: you will see one of her eyes—the one facing you—but unlike human eyes, hers will be a single dot. Eyes in Lineland have no features and